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[00:14:22] The House will come to order. Members, please take your seats. Head page. House is now in session. All persons not entitled to privileges of the floor, please retire to the gallery.

[00:14:40] The members will rise and be led in prayer by Reverend Dr. Ben Jenkins, Boyce Baptist Church, Boyce, and remain standing for the Pledge of Allegiance of the Flag of the United States of America, which will be led by the Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Hearken to the word of the Lord. Hearken to me, ye that follow after righteousness, ye that seek the Lord.

[00:15:08] Remember the rock from whence you are hewn. Let us pray. Almighty God, we thank you today for the privilege and indeed high honor to gather in this hallowed space where so many before us have gathered, responding to the call to lead and to guide this commonwealth.

[00:15:27] Grant us, audience, we pray, your blessings upon these who now embrace their calling to shoulder the responsibility for which they have been entrusted by you and the citizens of Virginia. Almighty God, grant that as these delegates look with anticipation to leading this great state let us not fail as we approach this 250th anniversary of our nation established in your precepts and according to your design to remember the rock from which we were hewn that we fail not to contemplate that virginia the mother of presidents was carved out of the wilderness by those seeking freedoms they had been denied

[00:16:05] tyranny they sought to escape and the free exercise of those certain inalienable rights endowed to them and to their posterity by the Creator. Grant, O Lord, that we do not abandon the leadership, indeed the bedrock upon which this great commonwealth rests, of Washington, Jefferson, Madison, Monroe, Harrison, Tyler, Taylor, and Wilson. These who sought your leadership, let us fail not to follow their example, that as we come before this august body today, we pray that as they look to you for wisdom and knowledge, you will grant it abundantly.

[00:16:43] Before you, O God, you who give rulers their power and take it away, we come expectantly, looking ever forward, even as we remember the rock, the stone which the builders once rejected, who has now become the head of the corner. Jesus, who taught us when we pray to say, Our Father, who art in heaven, hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come, thy will be done, in earth as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread, and forgive us our trespasses, as we forgive those who trespass against us and lead us not into temptation but deliver us from

[00:17:21] evil for thine is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever amen the members will answer

[00:18:02] the roll call by indicating their presence on the electronic voting board clerk will close the roll mr speaker a quorum is present pursuant to house rule three i've examined and approved the journal house of delegates for january 21st 2025 motions and resolutions under rule 39 pursuant to the provisions of Rule 40 are now in order. Does the Clerk have any announcements or communications?

[00:18:33] Two announcements, Mr. Speaker. One, there is a supplemental calendar, one for today, Thursday, January 22nd. It is informational only, but there is available. It's available to the public. It's available to the members via IHOD, and it's also hard copies are available Sergeant at Arms desk. Also, I'd remind the members, today and tomorrow are the last two days for your composite picture if you're so inclined to if you're new please go get one if you want to get a new one that's great too but tomorrow's the last day they're on site here over in the general assembly building so see me if you have questions this speaker with that this

[00:19:09] first person morning hour pursuant to house rule 40 speaker request that you use your request speak button for the aforementioned items listed for reference up on the voting board. Delegate from Warren Delegate Oaks. Thank you Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate answer the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker and members of the House, the invocation today was delivered by Reverend Dr. Benjamin Jenkins of Boyce Baptist Church in big old Clark County, Virginia. He is a devoted pastor, missionary, and servant leader who has faithfully served his congregation and community for nearly two decades. Reverend Dr. Jenkins was first called

[00:19:46] to Boyce Baptist Church as interim pastor in July of 2005 and was soon thereafter called as the full-time pastor in February of 2006. From the very beginning of his ministry, he brought with him a deep passion for missions and a heart for sharing the gospel beyond the walls of the church.

[00:20:06] His missionary work has taken him internationally, including multiple trips to Nicaragua, as well as a significant mission to Kenya, where he spent 12 days sharing the gospel with the Maasai people of the Rift Valley. In addition to his pastoral duties, Pastor Ben also serves the citizens of Clark County as the system chaplain to the law enforcement and fire and rescue. As a senior chaplain of the International Conference of Police Chaplains, as well as a member of regional critical incident stress management team, Pastor Ben seeks to provide comfort and support to the

[00:20:42] first responders who sacrifice so much for our communities. Today, we recognize Reverend Dr. Jenkins for his faithful ministry, his commitment to spreading the gospel, and his enduring service to others. Please help me welcome Pastor Ben to the House of Delegates. Welcome, Reverend Jenkins.

[00:21:12] Welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Roanoke City, Delegate Rasul. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an announcement. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker, ladies and gentlemen of the House. As a board member of the Center for Rural Virginia. I'm pleased to announce the first Rural Caucus Meeting of 2026. That'll be happening at 5 p.m. this afternoon at the ninth floor meeting room. Today's Rural Caucus Meeting will have the Secretary of Commerce and Trade, the Secretary of Ag, the Commissioner of VEDACS,

[00:21:49] and the State Forester. We hope that you'll be able to join us. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Arlington, Delegate Lopez. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. Delegate, ask the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. With us today in the gallery are the passionate young leaders of the Virginia Future Farmers of America, and I ask them to please rise.

[00:22:11] As a part of the national FFA organization, these students are committed to the future of agriculture and the development of critical skills for tomorrow's workforce. After being founded 100 years ago right here in 1926 in the Commonwealth of Virginia, FFA has grown into a nationwide organization with over 1 million members.

[00:22:29] And I'm honored to introduce these young leaders as they celebrate FFA's centennial anniversary. The representatives here are here on behalf of the 15,000 members across 232 agricultural education programs here in Virginia.

[00:22:45] And these students are honing skills in science, technology, and entrepreneurship while upholding FFA's core values, premier leadership, personal growth, and career success. As you interact with these young leaders today, you will witness their dedication to creating a thriving agricultural industry in the Commonwealth and their commitment to community service and living FFA's motto.

[00:23:08] Learning to do, doing to learn, earning to live, living to serve. Please join me in giving them a warm house welcome.

[00:23:29] Welcome. Welcome to the chamber today. One of them said they're going to take my job. The delegate from Henrico, Delegate Willett. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker and members of the House today, I am pleased to recognize the Certified Registered Nurse Anesthetists of Virginia as they observe National CRNA Week, and I'll ask if they please stand.

[00:23:54] Mr. Speaker, CRNAs are advanced practice nurses who provide patient-focused, safe, and effective anesthesia care to Virginians in every region of the Commonwealth. More than 2,400 CRNAs practice in Virginia, playing a vital role in ensuring access to anesthesia services, particularly in the rural and underserved communities.

[00:24:16] We're honored to have members of the Virginia Association of Nurse Anesthesiology with us today in the gallery as part of their legislative summit. Please join me in recognizing and thanking Virginia CRNAs for their dedication to high-quality, accessible care for the citizens of the Commonwealth, and I hope we'll give them a warm house welcome.

[00:24:33] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Y'all look so serious. They're like they're about to put somebody under. The delegate from Loudoun County, Delegate Risa.

[00:24:51] Good morning, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today in the gallery, we have the MOVE Chamber, and I would ask that they please rise. MOVE is a business chamber of commerce for Muslims and minorities, present today with more than 200 individuals who have traveled from across the Commonwealth to be here for their annual Advocacy Day.

[00:25:15] Joining them are members of the Adams Center Mosque from my district in Sterling, Daryl Hijra Mosque, the Virginia Muslim Civic League, the West End Islamic Center of Richmond, and ICNA Virginia. Muslim Virginians, over 400,000 strong, are an integral part of the fabric of our Commonwealth.

[00:25:33] They contribute as small business owners, health care professionals, engineers, educators, public servants, and civic volunteers. They strengthen communities through service, charitable giving, and mentoring of our youth. They also strengthen local economies with small businesses, creating jobs, and investing in our communities.

[00:25:52] In every corner of Virginia, Muslim Virginians help build a commonwealth that is stronger, more innovative, and more connected. Our guests are here to meet their elected representatives, share their experiences, and participate in the legislative process, demonstrating the kind of civic involvement we always welcome.

[00:26:10] I hope it is the will of the body to join me in extending a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:26:27] Delegate Ben-Henriko, Delegate McQuinn. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I'll rise for an introduction and an announcement. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, today it is my pleasure to, I'm going to ask them to stand if they're in the gallery, Virginia Union University.

[00:26:49] It is my honor to rise and to recognize one of the Virginia's most historic and impactful institution of higher education, Virginia Union University, located in the heart of the city. For 160 years, Virginia Union University has served as a pillar of academic excellence, leadership development, and social transformation, educating generations of students who have gone on to serve our commonwealth and our nation with distinction.

[00:27:15] And many of those individuals are in this room today serving as legislators, and I'm going to ask them to stand at some point. All of the fellow VUU alumni, again, I would ask them to stand. And we today are joined by individuals under the leadership of President and CEO, Dr. Hakeem J. Lucas, and the university.

[00:27:38] They continue to experience significant growth, innovation, and national recognition while remaining deeply committed to access, equity, and student success. And so I ask that the body would just join me in recognizing VUU for its enduring legacy, its continual impact, and its vital role in shaping the future leaders of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[00:28:00] Also, they are accompanied by the Mayor of Blackstone and the Head of Blackstone Economic Development. Please join me in recognizing them at this moment. Thank you.

[00:28:19] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol Day. Announcement. And you have an announcement. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I just want to announce once again the 2026 Cancer Caucus meeting and reception, which will be held tomorrow, Friday, January the 23rd at 8 a.m. in House Subcommittee Room 9.

[00:28:36] We've had probably about 10 of my colleagues who have responded, and we ask you to please come by. This is, we are Senator William, Senator Stanley, Senator Jones, Delegate Herring, and myself are hosting this event, and at this point we have VCU Massive Cancer Center, the University of Virginia Cancer Center, Hampton University Proton Therapy Institute, Cancer Action Coalition of Virginia American Cancer Society, Virginia Breast Cancer Foundation, Ask Childhood Cancer Foundation, and the Blood Cancer United.

[00:29:14] All of those groups will be in attendance to help, again, inform us and make us aware in the world of cancer, where all of us are impacted by, that we can learn much more about awareness and about the progress that's being made and how they are advancing, the progress and the advancements.

[00:29:37] So thank you, Mr. Speaker. The delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Sebo. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today I have the honor of introducing Kind Humans for Democracy. I please ask them to stand.

[00:29:54] Kind Humans for Democracy is a grassroots advocacy group based in Vienna. The group focuses on actions to support their neighbors in need. They champion immigrant rights, affordability concerns, health care costs, reproductive rights, marriage equality, gun violence prevention, and environmental justice.

[00:30:11] Their membership continues to grow and is supported by citizens who lead with kindness, value human dignity, display empathy for others, and support justice in all aspects of the law. I hope the House will join me in extending Kind Humans for Democracy a warm House welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:30:39] Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Maldonado. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purpose of an announcement. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Just a friendly reminder that today we will have the first caucus meeting for the Technology and Innovation Caucus, where Delegate Chair Hayes will be joining us to discuss some technology items, and we'll also be talking about the landscape across federal, state, and local AI issues.

[00:31:04] It's going to be in House Room 800 in the General Assembly Building, and you can stop by there right on your way to the Rural Caucus meeting. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Delegate from Freddysburg, Delegate Cole. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. In the gallery today is the Virginia Black Chamber of Commerce, and I'd ask that they would please rise.

[00:31:29] The Virginia Black Chamber of Commerce was founded in 2020 by Arneisha and Tracy Hall, and the VABBC is driven by a powerful commitment to entrepreneurship, innovation, and economic opportunity. Through advocacy, leadership, and initiatives like the Virginia Black Business Directory, Black Restaurant Week, and more, The V.A.B.C.C. is helping black businesses grow, connect, and thrive across our commonwealth.

[00:31:53] I hope it will be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:32:08] The delegate from Richmond City, Delegate Cousins. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for the purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you. Mr. Speaker, in the gallery today are members of the Board of Virginians for the Arts and other arts advocates from around the commonwealth in support of Arts Advocacy Day.

[00:32:28] I ask that they please stand to be recognized. Virginians for the Arts is a statewide nonprofit organization dedicated to securing adequate funding for the arts and educating all Virginians on the significant role arts and culture play in our economy and quality of life.

[00:32:47] The arts are a vital part of our lives, driving economic development, inspiring creativity, fostering cultural understanding, and broadening perspectives, qualities that are crucial in a global economy and diverse society. Studies show that students engaged in the arts are higher academic achievers, developing the skills critical in today's workforce. I request that the members join me in extending a warm welcome and our collective gratitude to the arts community for their tireless efforts to ensure all Virginians have access to the power and beauty of the arts.

[00:33:24] Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Prince William, Delegate Henson. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I rise today for an introduction.

[00:33:42] Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I'd like to introduce the volunteers for Moms Demand Action, and I ask that they please stand. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Members of the House, the advocates are made up of dedicated parents and community members from across the Commonwealth who have traveled to Richmond to participate in their annual advocacy day.

[00:34:03] They are here to engage with the legislative process, to share their experiences and perspectives, and to participate in a way that strengthens our democracy. Their presence here today reflects a strong commitment to the Democratic participation and to being active, informed voices in their communities.

[00:34:21] You probably have seen them this morning. You will continue to see them throughout the day, and I will ask the House to give them a warm House welcome. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:34:42] The delegate from Arlington, Delegate Lopez. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for an introduction. The delegate has the floor. For over 40 years, CASA has served as the region's preeminent immigrant advocacy organization.

[00:34:58] And if they're in the gallery, if they could please rise. Representing a lifetime membership of over 189,000 Latino, African, and working-class individuals, now a national organization, CASA is primarily operating in Maryland, Georgia, Pennsylvania, and Virginia.

[00:35:16] In Virginia alone, the movement is over 11,000 members strong, and it's rapidly growing throughout Fairfax, Prince William County, Richmond, and Hampton Roads, and other parts of the Commonwealth. CASA has been at the forefront of fighting for civil rights in recent years, from upholding birthright citizenship challenges at the federal level to halting the wrongful deportation of members.

[00:35:36] The organization has proven itself a fearless defender of human rights. It always puts humanity first by focusing on civil rights, climate justice, health care, access, and economic development. Today, alongside a coalition of dedicated allies, they are advancing the community safety and trust

agenda. It's a vital legislative roadmap addressing the rising cost of living in Virginia, the affordability crisis, and the protection of Virginia families by building trust with their localities.

[00:36:00] By empowering members to lead their own campaigns for justice, CASA continues to redefine what is possible for organized and socially conscious working-class communities at the local, state, and national levels. Mr. Speaker, I hope everyone will join me in recognizing their profound impact and giving them a warm house welcome welcome welcome to the capitol today the delegate from alexandria delegate bennett parker thank you mr speaker i rise to the purpose of an introduction

[00:36:36] the delegate has the floor thank you mr speaker today in the gallery we are joined by students demand action members from across the commonwealth as well as cornerstone craftsmen if they could all please stand students demand action is comprised of young activists committed to ending gun violence in our country students demand action was created by students in response to the 2018 tragic mass shooting in Parkland, Florida that claimed the lives of 17 students and teachers.

[00:37:03] Since that heartbreaking event, Students Demand Action has continued to advocate for meaningful policy change as we witnessed shooting after shooting and now live in a country where gun violence is the leading cause of death for children and teenagers. Students Demand Action now has 1,000 groups in high schools and universities across the country, and today we have students leaders from all across the Commonwealth representing Alexandria City High School, First Colonial High School, Hayfield Secondary School, the University of Virginia, and George Mason University.

[00:37:33] Cornerstone Craftsman is the community partner of Alexandria Moms Demand Action, and they are a nonprofit whose mission is to provide youth with instruction tools and mentoring so they can earn a livable wage with a viable career in the skilled trades, end generational poverty, keep youth safe from violence, and prevent justice system intervention.

[00:37:52] I love seeing our Commonwealth's young people engaged in the legislative process, and I ask that we give Students Demand Action and Cornerstone Craftsmen a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:38:11] Delegate from Norfolk, Delegate Glass. Mr. Speaker, I rise for the purposes of an introduction. Delegate, ask the floor. Gratitude, Mr. Speaker. In Virginia Beach and Norfolk, we have folks here showing up for more than just applause.

[00:38:28] We have groups like Teens with a Purpose, If They Would Rise, Souls, HR Mass, and Community First. These are folks who turn their pain into purpose. The names of their organizations are driven and born out of loss, but driven with love and fight back against the worse, gun violence.

[00:38:47] They are self-funded, teenage-led, started by mostly mothers who have lost their own. They have took their grief, planted it deep, and watched their purpose grow. These Virginians also walk the streets of high-crime neighborhoods, Holding hands, guiding youth, trying to break cycles.

[00:39:07] They are the boots on the ground, the interrupters, the revival. Today they are here because they believe in what we all should believe in, gun violence prevention work. I want to remember that Richmond, in Richmond, we must lift up the voices of people who do the healing first.

[00:39:26] And with that, Mr. Speaker, I ask, I request that the members of the body join me in extending them a warm house welcome.

[00:39:43] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. Pursuant to House Rule 30, the journal shall reflect that the following members are away on pressing personal business and are granted leave from today's session. Delegates Knight, Martinez, and McNamara. Clerk shall announce the next order.

[00:39:59] Mr. Speaker, based upon today's calendar, the second and third portions of the morning hour are not applicable. Clerk shall announce the next order, Mr. Speaker. And the fourth and final portion of the morning hour is reserved for member requests for points of personal privilege. Speaker asks you to use your request speak button to get into the queue, please.

[00:40:17] Delegate from Patrick County, Delegate Williams. Good morning, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. So I woke up this morning, and I learned that there was an appropriations committee hearing.

[00:40:35] I'm not on appropriations, so I usually just see the budget at the end. But it turns out that that's where the Democrats have chosen to route the referendum language that would both fund the special election they're trying to rush through and also set the date of the special election that they're trying to hold as quickly as possible.

[00:40:54] So let's look at what they did in HP 1384. They were able to rush through without filing an agenda for the public to look at and review. They had a short public hearing opportunity to speak, but on what?

[00:41:14] Nobody had any notice, and nobody even saw what the language was going to be. They've allocated $5 million in order to have this special election. That really, you know, chalk one up to affordability right there. And you've got, let's see, oh, this money is going to go to set up the special election, but also inform the voters.

[00:41:41] Educate the voters. Who gets to educate the voters? It would be the Board of Elections. And the Board of Elections are controlled by who? The Democrats. So the Democrats get to write the educational material. And they also got to write the ballot questions. And I didn't really read it that much. It's relatively short and full of kumbaya.

[00:42:01] It basically says, pass this, so everything's fair, bright, sunny, and sunshines. But it says nothing else about what it actually does. And so, Mr. Speaker, today, on behalf of myself and the rest of the GOP caucus that you see in this house today, we have introduced the ballot question Fairness and Transparency Act.

[00:42:22] And what it would do, Mr. Speaker, is it would slow this train down, because that is what we were doing, rushing, rushing, rushing. I know that Delegate Simon is always concerned about rushing out of time, running out of time, but we have time, folks.

[00:42:38] There's 90 days, right? Oh, wait, you guys want to get rid of that one, too. Okay, so what we need to do is put this ballot question, the language, to an independent commission. We need to make sure that everyone understands what they're reading and voting on.

[00:42:57] We need to make sure that they know if they vote yes, it means this. If they vote no, it means this. That is why my bill sets up a nine-member independent commission that would draft that language and then submit it to the Board of Elections in order to process the regular old timeline.

[00:43:19] it meets the 90 day rule and it also gives a 10 day buffer before the ballots would need to be printed i've tried to figure out everything you could possibly argue against because i know you hate transparency you want to run this through as fast as possible but today we need to slow this down and we need to give it to the people you guys are so confident that the people will decide we're going to let the people decide even though they did decide two-thirds of them in 2020 that we're going to let them decide again. You know how? We're going to sell them a false statement.

[00:43:52] We're going to give them the wrong question. So this bill fixes that, Mr. Speaker, and it does it within the deadline. In fact, you all have said it for April 21st. By my math, I don't think you can even do that based on the 90 days since we haven't even passed the Senate joint resolution, which needs to be passed but I calculated it out till April 27th so my bill is only a week later than your timeline but it allows the entire nation or the entire commonwealth to be able to read and

[00:44:26] understand the language thank you Mr. Speaker the delegate from Buckingham delegate Garrett thank you Mr. Speaker and I'm going to apologize to you because I the nature of uh what purpose of the delegate rise rise on a point of personal privilege the delegate has the floor now you can apologize right i'm so sorry mr speaker because because you know about two-thirds of the time i stand up i start with i love you and i do but the nature of the debate on we know that um the nature of the

[00:45:04] debate the expedited and sort of surreptitious nature of the debate on the on which uh the delegate from patrick county just spoke prevented me from coming to you in advance and so i rise today on a point of personal privilege because i care about you i care about all you guys and i want y'all to be embarrassed. I don't want y'all to be embarrassed because I think that probably you missed this. And I quote, "This is good news for Virginia and the country.

[00:45:28] Gerrymandering is detrimental to our democracy and it weakens our individual voices that form our electorates. Opposing gerrymandering should be a strong bipartisan priority." And I read that to you, Mr. Speaker, because that's from Spanberger for Virginia. So I know that it's going to be embarrassing when Governor Spanberger stands up and vociferously opposes this this power hungry naked grab of gerrymandering audacity but clearly she'll be consistent to her word where she said gerrymandering is bad and fighting against gerrymandering should be a bipartisan priority so if we'd had a little bit more lead time on your intentions to surreptitiously

[00:46:05] ram this through the appropriations committee of all places i could have told you you don't want to do this because clearly your governor opposes it she said so and so it's with the heaviest of hearts that i inform you that you all might want to hit the brakes on this because clearly the governor doesn't support this. She's unequivocal in her attack of gerrymandering. So I just encourage you all to speak to the governor because I'm sure she'll be consistent. And since she didn't like it before, she won't like it now, Mr. Speaker. And I only do that because I care. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Another delegate that cares, delegate from Newport News,

[00:46:44] Delegate Price. Good morning, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I'm sorry. I had to scribble because I had to keep up with the amount of misinformation that was coming out so that I could try to help those that are newer to this body remember what I know to be the rules because I learned it by watching Republicans.

[00:47:15] And so it is really interesting to me that since I've been here, not too long, just 10 years, that I have learned so much about following the rules that I am proud to report, Mr. Speaker, that we are in fact

following the rules. So because I'm not sure that all of the members on this floor understand the process, there is a house joint resolution that would be the proposed constitutional amendment. Then there is a vehicle for enabling legislation that describes what it's going to do. And then there is explainer language that DLS comes up with, which Mr. Speaker is

[00:47:53] neutral because DLS is not Democrat or Republican, as I keep my decorum. This time we needed an appropriation because this is a special election for House Joint Resolution 4. There is no appropriation needed for House Joint Resolutions 1 through 3 because they will be happening with an already planned election. Mr. Speaker, they're also hanging their hat on the outdated and obsolete section of 30-13, which the Code Commission voted before redistricting even

[00:48:32] became a topic twice to repeal that obsolete language, obsolete language. And I will point out that that first vote was bipartisan. Second, I would also state that the gentleman's math is wrong. In fact, because there is no Senate Joint Resolution 4, and so we are operating off house joint resolution. Mr. Speaker, also, I'm not embarrassed. And I don't think the governor is going to be either. What I think is embarrassing is to have been quiet up to this point while

[00:49:09] gerrymandering was happening across our nation when some people in this room thought it was going to help them. But now it's real loud. And so I'm embarrassed for them because the hypocrisy of silence and now yelling is really, um, interesting. So I really just want to set the record straight, Mr. Speaker, we are following the rules. We are following the precedent and we are following, uh, what I learned from watching from them. And it is really mind boggling, Mr. Speaker,

[00:49:47] that we continue to say 2020 as if the new normal of 2026 is not bonkers compared to where we thought our country would be, and that some of us refuse to let others take us so far back that some of us would still be in chains. And with that, Mr. Speaker, I exuberantly, exuberantly support House Bill 1384 and the appropriation that comes with it in order to offset the cost to our

[00:50:18] localities. Thank you. All right, pipe down. The delegate from Prince William, Delegate Guzman.

[00:50:38] Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I rise for a request. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I would like to request to go back to the first morning hour for a purpose of an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Today we are joined in the gallery by the president and members of the Brentsville District High School Future Farmers of America Chapter, a student-led organization who have made the trip down today from Knoxville.

[00:51:04] I ask the members to please stand to be recognized. The Future of America recognized Brentsville District High School, Mr. Speaker, with a National Chapter Three Star Award.

[00:51:20] The award is given to chapters that incorporate all 15 Future Farmers of America quality standards into their program through events they host, attend, or assist within the school, community, and across the country. The National Chapter Three Standard Award is one of the top awards for chapters to earn.

[00:51:41] Brentsville Future Farmers of America is celebrating its 97th anniversary this year. Their standard of building communities, promoting a healthy lifestyle and growing leaders, transcends state lines and shapes the future of agriculture in Virginia.

[00:51:58] And they work really hard to keep it alive in Prince William County. I will ask the members of the House to please join me in giving them a warm house welcome. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[00:52:19] Delegate from Prince William, Delegate Sewell. Mr. Speaker, I rise for an introduction. The delegate has to be in the fourth morning hour, so you want to go back to the first morning hour. Oh, I'm sorry. I thought we were still there. Mr. Speaker, I rise, wrote the request. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I request that we go back to the first morning hour.

[00:52:37] For what purpose? For an introduction. The delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. We're going to get this straight. Mr. Speaker, joining us in the gallery today are advocates here for Planned Parenthood Advocates of Virginia's annual lobby day. And I would ask them to please stand.

[00:53:00] Planned Parenthood Advocates of Virginia is a statewide advocacy organization dedicated to preserving and expanding access to sexual and reproductive health care in the Commonwealth through legislation, public education, electoral activity, and litigation. Their mission is to ensure that individuals and families have the freedom, information, and ability to make their own informed decisions about their bodies and their futures.

[00:53:24] Excuse me, their health and their futures. Today, they represent thousands of Virginians who believe our commonwealth is stronger when people have the autonomy to make personal decisions about their bodies, families, and lives. They are here today advocating for policies that protect access to care, particularly at a moment when the federal government, through the passage of H.R. 1, has blocked Planned Parenthood from being reimbursed for serving Medicaid patients, jeopardizing access to basic health care for low-income Virginians, including birth control, cancer screenings, STI testing,

[00:54:02] and primary care. Today also marks the 53rd anniversary of Roe v. Wade's decision. On this occasion, these advocates are especially grateful that this body has already passed the Reproductive Freedom Constitutional Amendment to protect reproductive health care and affirm that these deeply personal decisions belong to Virginians and their families and not the government. I hope it will be the pleasure of the body to give them a warm house welcome.

[00:54:32] Okay. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today. The delegate from Bedford, Delegate Griffin. Mr. Speaker, I rise for a point of personal privilege. The delegate has the floor. Mr. Speaker, I think that I probably speak for all 100 of us. When we went out on the campaign trail and we promised that we would come here And we would make lives of our citizens better We would represent them We would make it easier for them to be able to afford things

[00:55:09] And yet I come in here today And I hear speeches on Gerrymandering Being in chains again Abortion None of it has to do with what we were sent here to do today Honestly at this point I'm being embarrassed in front of my friends Because some of y'all have gone viral Over the last week With bills that are the most left wing things that we've seen in 100 years.

[00:55:40] They're revolutionary in nature. Y'all remember when the great Mark Early was here? I anticipate we'll see him back. He gave us that Chesterton quote. He said, you know, when you go out of the field and you see a fence, make sure that you don't tear it down without knowing what it's there for, right?

[00:56:00] So we heard the governor give her speech, and we've seen the bills that have been put forward, right? We saw the pro-fraud bill the Democrats put forward this week. We saw the slush fund for

transgender surgeries.

[00:56:17] We've seen Qatari lobbyists on the college boards. We've seen everything come forward except things that will actually make Americans' lives better. The first thing the Democrats did when they took back over was raising our electric bills again by entering us back into Reggie.

[00:56:35] People think it's going to cost us $4.40 every single month on our electric bills. And yet today, y'all are once again focused on Washington, D.C. and on gerrymandering. I think we have an obligation to stand up and to do what's right.

[00:56:54] But I think here's the struggle I have. I know some of y'all are going to try to do what the governor talked about in the first half of her speech. You remember the first half? She said, I'm going to focus on energy, and I'm going to focus on housing, and I'm going to focus on employment.

[00:57:09] You remember the first half? And then in the second half, she went on all the left-wing talking points, right? All the stuff we hear and hear every day. But you can't build and tear down at the same time. And so many of the bills, Mr. Speaker, that have been put forward so far are bills that tear us down.

[00:57:29] They're bills that divide us. They're bills that overturn hundreds of years of a society. I think it's corrosive when you try to do too much too quickly. And people online have rightly said that Virginia Democrats are trying to California Virginia and just what took California 30 years, you're all going to try to do it in two years.

[00:57:51] I know that some of you I know some of you And I know some of you are thinking That you can walk and chew gum at the same time And I understand where you're coming from But if I was to set out to build a building And half of my project was to tear things down And get rid of mandatory minimums for rapists A Democrat bill And the other part of my agenda to build a building Was to build up It wouldn't work And I think y'all are focused on the wrong thing So here we are six days into session And I'm hearing the same tired arguments

[00:58:28] that the most privileged among us are in chains or you want to talk about abortion or you want to focus on gerrymandering. It is wrong, Mr. Speaker. We were sent here to do a job. We can lower electric bills right now. We can save costs to Virginia taxpayers, but we have to step forward and do the right thing. Mr. Speaker, you can kill a lot of these bills in committee. We can focus on Virginia taxpayers, the people that live here. I know you're going to kill some of my bills, but it's a testament to how good they are the Democrats hate them Mr. Speaker we will not

[00:59:06] stop standing up for taxpayers we will not stop standing up for homeowners we will continue to fight for what's right whether our bills get killed or not thank you Mr. Speaker the delegate from Albemarle, delegate Carlson thank you Mr. Speaker I rise with the request to return to the first morning hour for the purpose of an introduction thank God the delegate has the floor thank you Mr. Speaker Here in the gallery today, we have members from the People's Coalition in Charlottesville.

[00:59:40] I ask that they please rise. Oh, no, sorry. My pauses are too long. Let me just move a little faster. The People's Coalition is a community-led organization made up of directly impacted Virginians, advocates, and family members working to strengthen fairness and accountability in our criminal justice system.

[01:00:03] They bring real-world experience into the policymaking process and work constructively with lawmakers to advance practical, community-centered solutions. I thank them for their civic leadership. I thank them even further for making the drive out here and visiting me. It's always a joy to see familiar faces, and I ask that the House please give them a warm welcome.

[01:00:28] Delegate from Henry County, Delegate Phillips. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. I have a request to return to the fourth morning hour for an introduction. The delegate has the floor.

[01:00:44] Hallelujah. Thank you, sir. Mr. Speaker, today in the gallery we are joined by members of the ARC of the South Side, if they would rise. It's one of the 21 chapters of the ARC of Virginia, the only statewide advocacy organization representing Virginians with all types of developmental disabilities and their families.

[01:01:00] They're in Richmond for the Southwest DD Advocacy Day, along with members of the ARC of the New River Valley and other advocates from our region of the Commonwealth. After meetings with legislators, they've joined over 150 individuals from all across the Commonwealth at the Bell Tower for the DD Rally at the Capitol.

[01:01:15] Organized by the ARC and Partnership with the Disability Law Center of Virginia, the Virginia Board for People with Disabilities, SEIU, Autism Societies of Northern Virginia and Central Virginia, Virginia Down Syndrome Association, D3, and Rev Up Virginia. The ARC and its chapters are advocating this session for increased rates for essential waiver services, funding for rental assistance, employment support, and opportunities, and ensuring disability rights are preserved and protected for those who are disabled.

[01:01:40] Would you please join me and give them a warm house welcome? Welcome. Welcome to the Capitol today.

[01:01:56] Delegate from Fairfax, Delegate Tran. Thank you so much, Mr. Speaker. I rise to request that we return to the first morning hour for the purpose of an introduction. Delegate, that's the floor. Thank you. So, Mr. Speaker and members of the House, joining us in the gallery today are advocates from Church World Service of Harrisonburg and Winchester, and I ask that they rise.

[01:02:18] For over 30 years, Church World Service has been welcoming refugees and immigrants from around the world to make their new homes in the Shenandoah Valley and across Virginia. Church World Service partners with faith communities, local organizations, and community leaders to empower Virginia's newest neighbors to build safe, stable, and successful lives in the commonwealth.

[01:02:40] Their work connects families with housing, education, health care, and legal services, while also advocating for the rights and dignity of refugees and immigrants across Virginia. Mr. Speaker, I ask that you and members of the House please join me in giving Church World Service a warm House welcome.

[01:02:57] Welcome, welcome to the Capitol today. Delegate from Henrico, Delegate McQuinn. Thank you, Mr. Speaker.

[01:03:15] Mr. Speaker, I rise to request that we go back to the first morning hour for introduction. The Delegate has the floor. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Mr. Speaker, I stood a few moments ago and did introduce VUU, and it's my understanding that they're in the gallery now, so I'm going to ask them to stand under the

leadership of President and CEO, Dr. Hakeem Lucas, and these very amazing young people who have been here today advocating on the behalf of education and for VUU.

[01:03:48] They are a unique and special group of individuals that I didn't want to lose this opportunity for us to give them an amazing round of applause for their leadership, and not just what they're doing today, but what they will do tomorrow. Thank you, Mr. Speaker. Please rise with me and give them a shout.

[01:04:07] Clerk will call the calendar. Mr. Speaker, the calendar for today, Thursday, January 22nd, 2026. There is no business before the House today, Mr. Speaker.

[01:04:23] Per House Rule 51, the House is returned to the morning hours. Does the clerk have any additional announcement or communication? No communication, simply a meeting schedule announcement, a busy afternoon and morning. It is as follows. The Committee on General Laws is meeting a half hour after adjournment approximately at 1:30.

[01:04:41] They'll be on the second floor, House Committee Room B, and then once they're finished, Two of their subcommittees will be meeting in the same room. First, the Professions Occupation Administrative Process subcommittee. Once the full committee is done, and once that subcommittee is done, then the Housing Consumer Protection subcommittee, they'll be meeting 15 minutes after adjournment just get the room set.

[01:05:01] So general law is two subs. Then a half hour after adjournment today, approximately 1:30, the Committee on Labor and Commerce will be meeting. They'll be in the lower level, House Committee Room A. And then once they're finished, the Subcommittee number two will be meeting, and then once number two subcommittee of Labor and Commerce is finished, then subcommittee three.

[01:05:21] So Labor and Commerce two subs. As was mentioned earlier, the Technology and Innovation Caucus will be meeting at 345 in the House Committee Room 8, up on the eighth floor. At four o'clock today, the Health and Human Services, Social Services subcommittee, they'll be meeting, like I said, at four in House Committee Room C on the second floor.

[01:05:44] The Public Safety Committee's Firearms Subcommittee, they're meeting at 4.30. That'll be on the House North Subcommittee room on the second floor. The Transportation Innovation Subcommittee is canceled. And then, as mentioned before, the Rural Caucus will be meeting 4.45.

[01:06:03] They'll be in the ninth floor of Subcommittee room. So that rounds out the afternoon's activities looking ahead to tomorrow, Friday, January 23rd. The finance subcommittee meeting is canceled, so our first activity is CC&T Committee on County, Cities, and Towns, excuse me, subcommittee number three.

[01:06:24] They're going to be meeting at 7 a.m. in the north subcommittee room, again on the second floor. I'm sorry, they're going to actually be on the second floor, I apologize, on house committee room B, 7 a.m., CC&T, sub three. then um sub one is going to meet immediately in the same room once they're finished and then the full committee will uh meet in uh house committee room b at nine o'clock p and e subcommittee is not meeting uh but at 8 a.m public safety committee on public safety's meeting they'll be in the lower level house committee room a as mentioned previously also at eight the cancer caucus will be meeting they'll be up on the ninth floor in the uh ninth floor uh meeting room full

[01:07:04] Committee on Privileges and Elections will be meeting tomorrow. They're at 9 o'clock in House Committee Room C on the second floor. And then finally, in light of what time we're going in tomorrow, the Democratic caucus is meeting at 10 a.m. in House 1030. Excuse me, the Democratic caucus is meeting at 1030 in House Room 1, the Republican caucus at 1030 in House Room 2. Ms.

[01:07:24] Speaker, that's all the announcements I have at this time. Ms. Speaker, members of the House, the winter weather is coming we've made arrangements to change things for Saturday on the ceremonial swearing-ins for the freshmen delegates we're doing a couple in the morning and coming through will probably postpone the vast majority of them to the following Saturday but the speaker asked each of

[01:08:02] you all to pay attention we were trying to keep you up to date with information about what's going on we have a lot of business to get down to the administration it sounds like for the department of Virginia Department of Emergency Management, Capitol Police, we're all following that. They're probably going to be briefing the caucuses tomorrow about what's coming and where exactly.

[01:08:21] As best we know, we're right on the line here in Richmond. I know you all are going back around. This might not be the best weekend to be traveling if you don't have to, so bear that in mind. But we will keep you posted as best we can. And more information will be forthcoming later this afternoon and then certainly tomorrow.

[01:08:38] The debate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that when the House adjourns today, it adjourned to reconvene. tomorrow at 11 a.m. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that when the House adjourns today, adjourn to reconvene tomorrow at 11 a.m. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no.

[01:08:54] The motion is agreed to. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring. Mr. Speaker, I move that the House do now adjourn. The Delegate from Alexandria, Delegate Herring moves that the House do now adjourn. As many in favor, the motion will say aye. Those opposed, no. The motion is agreed to. The House stands adjourned tomorrow at 11 a.m.